POWER MESS

BAD PLANNING, POOR ECONOMICS AND LACK OF COORDINATION AMONG VARIOUS STAKEHOLDERS IN THE SECTOR PUSH THE COUNTRY INTO AN UNENDING VORTEX OF POWER WOES

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Electricity is the lifeblood of a country's economic growth and development, powering industry and transport, running irrigation pumps for agriculture and lighting up homes and offices. It's oxygen to the digital world, so ubiquitous that its absence, even for a minute, causes discomfort and economic loss. This summer, as temperatures soared above 40 degrees centigrade in several parts of India as early as April, the need for uninterrupted electricity supply could not have been more acute. But that was not to be. India went through one of its worst-ever power crises in recent memory, with some parts of the country seeing 16-hour power outages as states battled the massive mismatch between power produced and distributed, and the rising demand. States such as Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Punjab, Rajasthan, Jharkhand, Haryana and Andhra Pradesh fared the worst, with many others expected to follow.

On April 29, the demand for power touched 207 GW, the highest ever the